

How Many Poles in a Multipolar World? A Look Ahead to 2050

Zhihu column · 2026-01-02

I. The Multipolar World Has Arrived

Our world has gradually moved out of the situation of American domination that followed the end of the Cold War. The power to decide international political and economic affairs has been dispersing to several great powers and blocs of powers. Since China's rise has already forced the United States to acknowledge the fact of multipolarity, the multipolar world is here.

In recent years American foreign policy has undergone its most marked change in decades, yet because of a series of changes since President Trump took office, this transformation has gone largely unnoticed. Since the end of the Second World War, mainstream politicians of both American parties believed that the United States was the economic, military, and moral leader of the world and should remain so. But in a recent interview with Meghan Kelly, the new Secretary of State, Marco Rubio, quietly declared that multipolarity is not only the state the Trump administration seeks as normal but the administration's preference. He further said, "We currently live in a multipolar world, and the United States and China are the main participants." This statement is a startling change in the paradigmatic language and tone of American foreign policy, overturning decades of bipartisan consensus. Source: Rubio's multipolar world

As for why the future is multipolar, rather than China taking America's place and building a new imperialist system or a new "tributary" system — this was thought through long ago when China's leadership decided to integrate into the global capitalist system. China's policymakers knew well that the rapid growth of their strength depended, apart from internal advantages of system and population, to a very large degree on the industrial and technological transfer brought by globalization. Globalization will not stop at East Asia; the door of industrialization cannot be welded shut by China; later, new regions will complete industrialization, and Chinese capital will itself join the historical process of exporting industry. There is therefore no chance of China replacing the United States in single-power hegemony.

After the end of the Cold War, the United States, having lost its rival, became the "sole superpower." Driven by the feverish mood of the "end of history," it intensified its export of values and its hegemonic behavior, and the international order passed through a brief "unipolar moment." But economic globalization soon promoted the flow and diffusion of economic and technological strength. The EU,

China, Japan, Russia, and India accelerated their economic development and raised their voices on world peace and development, forming a weighty influence. Comrade Deng Xiaoping said in March 1990: "The situation in which the US and the Soviet Union monopolized everything is changing. The world order will be tripolar, quadripolar, or pentapolar... In the so-called multipolarity, China counts as one pole." He regarded "multipolarization" as an inevitable trend in the evolution of the international order, believed it would bring new divisions and realignments, and held that international affairs should be handled and settled by all countries through equal consultation, not dominated by a few great powers. Source: Forum special article | Fu Ying: China injects more stability and certainty into a multipolarizing world — the author is a senior fellow of the China Institute of Contemporary International Relations

At present, China, Russia, Europe, India, Southeast Asia, the Middle East, and even the United States all believe the world has entered multipolarity. But this multipolarity is built on a highly globalized economy; running alongside the multipolar process is the transnationalization of capital, leaping over national and regional borders. Until a world government appears, however, it is still nation-states and regional unions of nation-states — the "poles" of the so-called multipolar world — that decide world economic and political affairs.

Economic globalization is undergoing a historic restructuring. The American-led model of globalization — the dollar as the world's reserve currency, US debt absorbing global capital, the American market absorbing global exports — is increasingly untenable, and America's role in the global economy is bound to decline step by step. Trump's protectionist policies and tariff weapons aim to build a new global supply-chain system centered on North America, but they clearly cannot achieve a complete decoupling from China, nor can they strip China out of the global supply chain. The world economy is unlikely to split into two hemispheres or two systems; the Cold War situation of two isolated and competing production systems — socialism (CMEA) versus capitalism (Bretton Woods plus the EEC) — is unlikely to return. Source: Zhao Xiaozhuo: The multipolar world is accelerating toward us — the author is a researcher at the War Studies Institute of the Academy of Military Sciences

On supply chains, see my other answers: "Can the US unite the world to turn China into an island, isolated from world trade?" and "Can China and the US coexist peacefully, or is war inevitable in the end?"

Although multipolarity has become a consensus, how many poles are there in the multipolar world? What strength of country or alliance can be called a pole?

II. The Standard for a "Pole"

What strength can be called a pole? It cannot be said that daring to challenge hegemony makes a pole — then Venezuela, Iran, and North Korea would each count, which clearly does not hold. To be a pole

of the multipolar world, one must be able to influence global affairs, to participate in the discussion and decision of global political and economic issues, to be a force with global reach. A force that can only defend its own doorstep from attack clearly does not qualify.

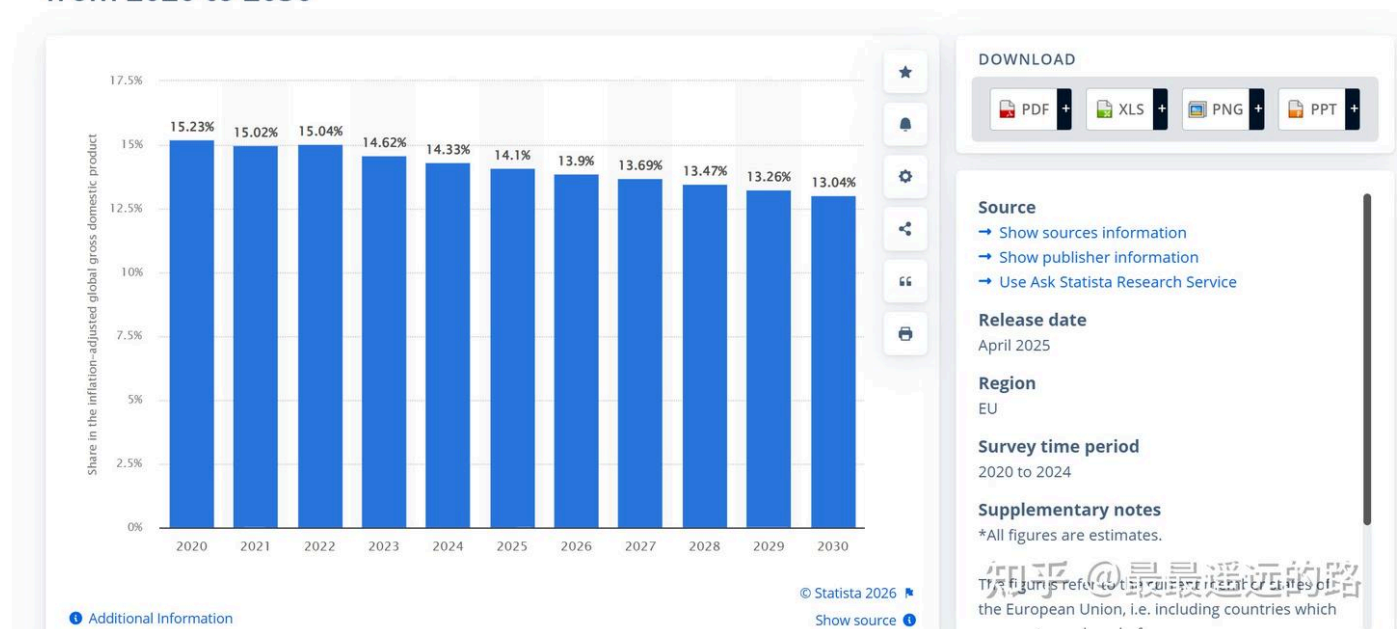
At present the most widely recognized poles with world influence are four: China, the US, Russia, and Europe. We can judge what qualifies as a pole on the basis of these forces. China and the US need no elaboration — both are strong politically, economically, and militarily. The main consideration is the EU and Russia.

(1) Economy

Consider the EU first. Its GDP share of the world, on a PPP basis, is about 10–15 percent; nominal GDP is also around 15–17 percent. For reference, in 2013, when the Chinese leadership put forward the Belt and Road Initiative, China's PPP share of the world was about 18 percent and its nominal share about 12 percent. On the whole, an economic scale of over 10 percent of the world gives the economic strength to claim to be a pole.

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European Union: Share in global gross domestic product based on purchasing-power-parity from 2020 to 2030



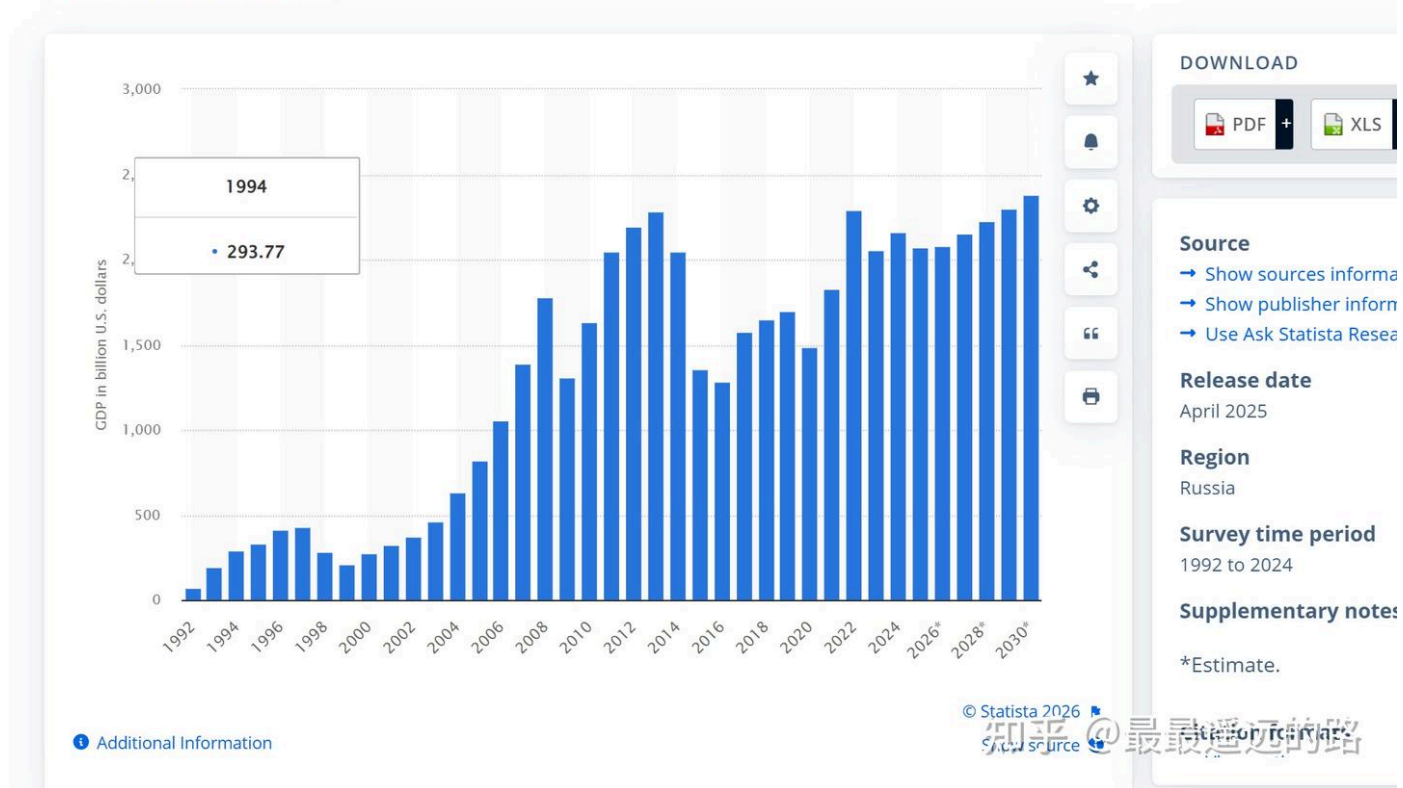
Source: <https://www.statista.com/statistics/253512/share-of-the-eu-in-the-inflation-adjusted-global-gross-domestic-product/>

Russia is worse off. In 2013, before the annexation of Crimea, Russia's share of world GDP was at its historical peak: about 3 percent nominal, and about 3.4 percent by PPP — about the same. For comparison, India's nominal share of world GDP in 2013 was under 3 percent; in 2024 it was 3-point-something percent, and some people dignify it with the title of "pole." But the world generally

does not think Russia is famous for economic strength, and India is judged more on future growth space than on the present.

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Russia: Gross domestic product (GDP) in current prices from 1992 to 2030 (in billion U.S. dollars)



Source: <https://www.statista.com/statistics/253512/share-of-the-eu-in-the-inflation-adjusted-global-gross-domestic-product/>

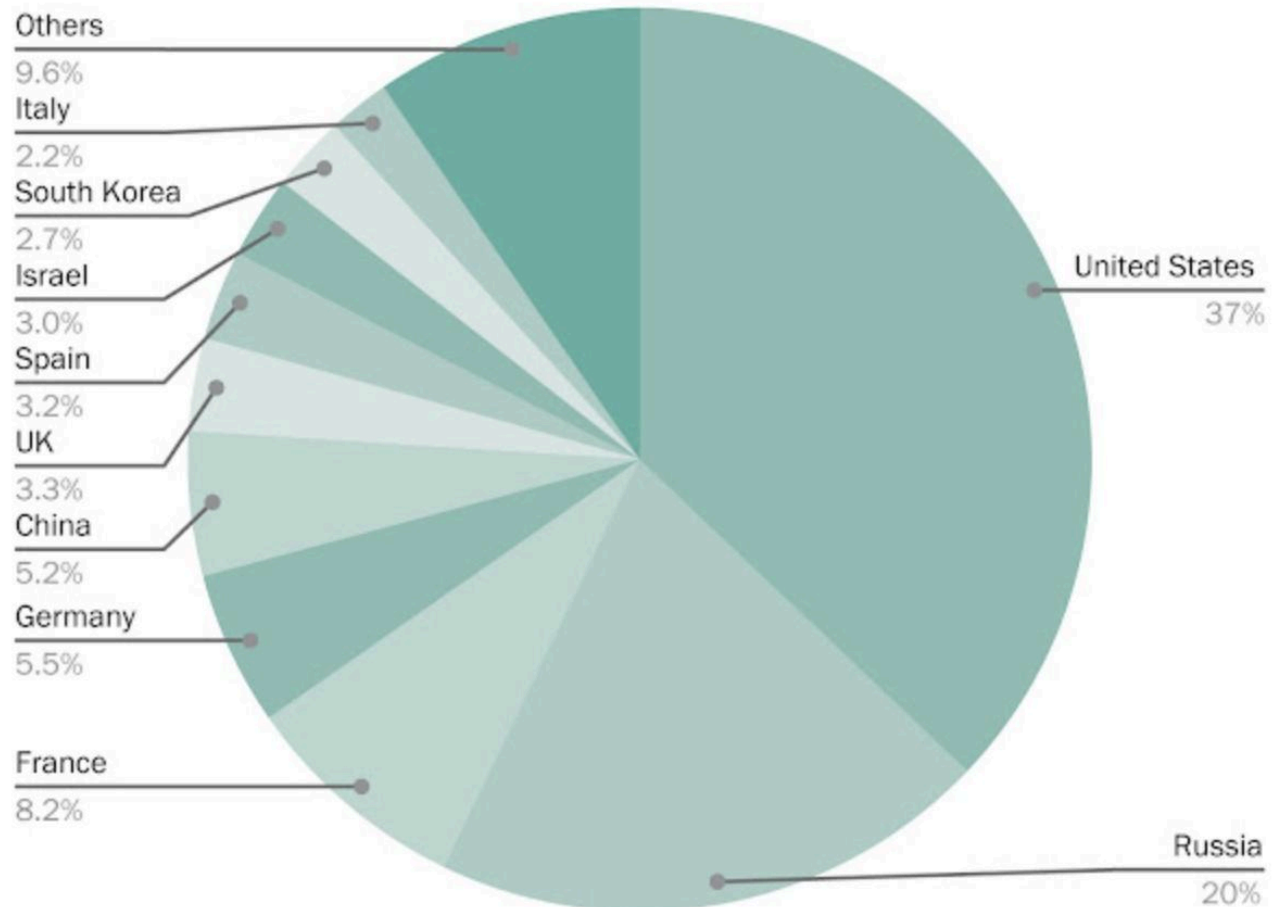
Economically alone, a pole of the multipolar world can be considered to need a GDP share above 10 percent of the world to be a true pole; if militarily or politically strong, this can be relaxed to about 5 percent.

(2) Military

The share of world military equipment exports reflects a country's military-industrial strength — and acceptance on the international market shows that quality or cost-effectiveness is good. Most military equipment sold is conventional weapons usable in real conflicts, so arms sales have a major impact on the global geopolitical balance and are thus a key indicator.

From the standpoint of arms sales, before the Russia–Ukraine war Russia's share was 20 percent, the main European countries together 19.1 percent, and with unlisted countries probably around 20 percent too. Of the recognized "poles," the smallest share is China's, about 5 percent.

GLOBAL SHARE OF MAJOR ARMS EXPORTS BY THE 10 LARGEST EXPORTERS, 2016–20



Source: SIPRI Arms Transfers Database, Mar. 2021.

www.sipri.org

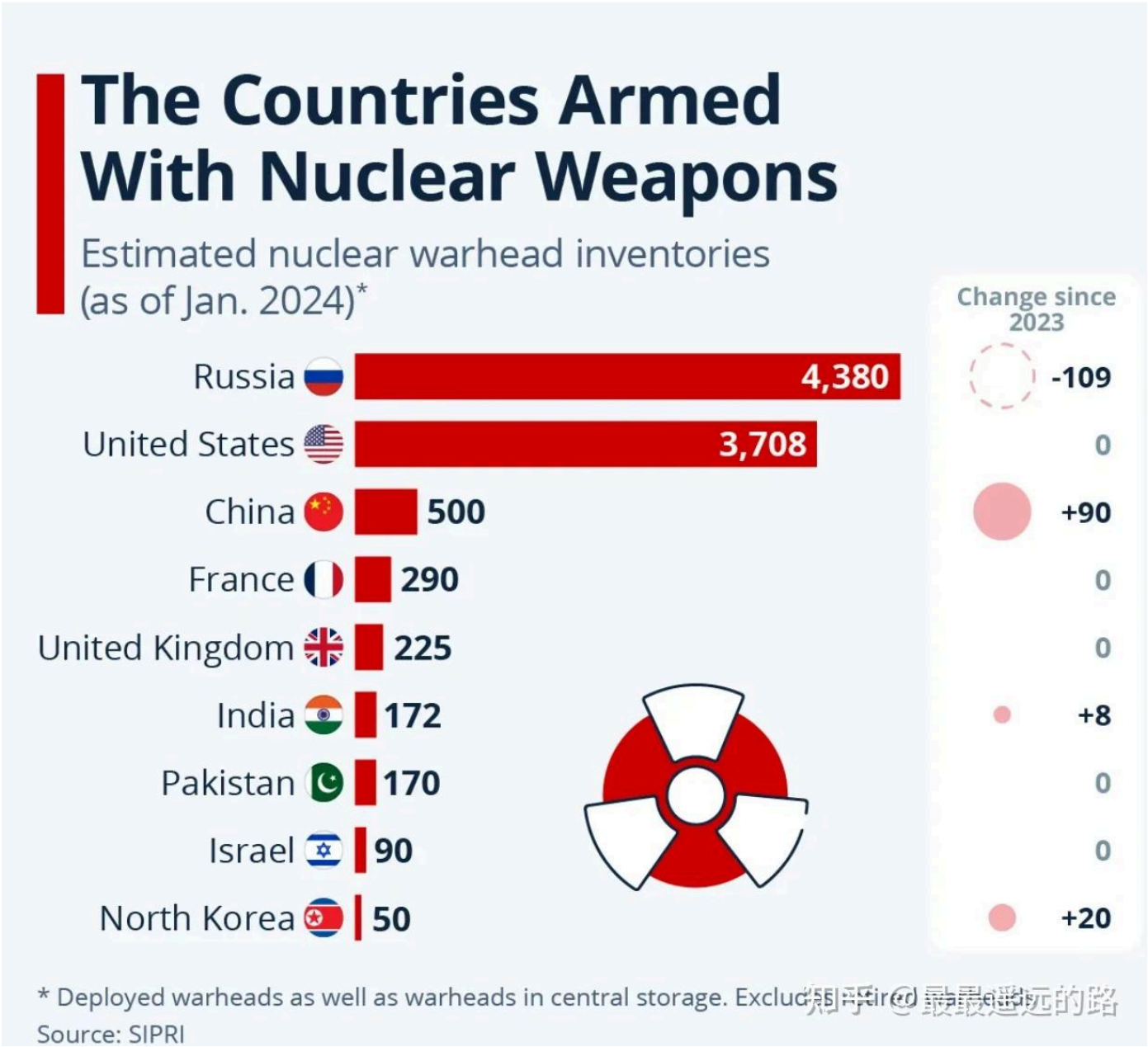
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Source: <https://thedeaddistrict.blogspot.com/2021/03/new-statistics-of-sipri-about-globe.html>

Another global-reach factor is strategic weapons: the size of the nuclear arsenal, delivery capability, and second-strike capability.

In nuclear arsenals, Russia is an undisputed nuclear power, and it frequently invokes its powerful arsenal to claim a say in global affairs. The EU's (France's) nuclear force is small, but France's delivery capability and survivability (submarines) are strong. Apart from the permanent members of the Security Council, no other country has global strike capability. Yet nuclear weapons are for self-defense: having them means no one dares to use military force to negate your existence. But using nukes to claim a say in global affairs easily turns you into Russia — reduced to having Medvedev issue

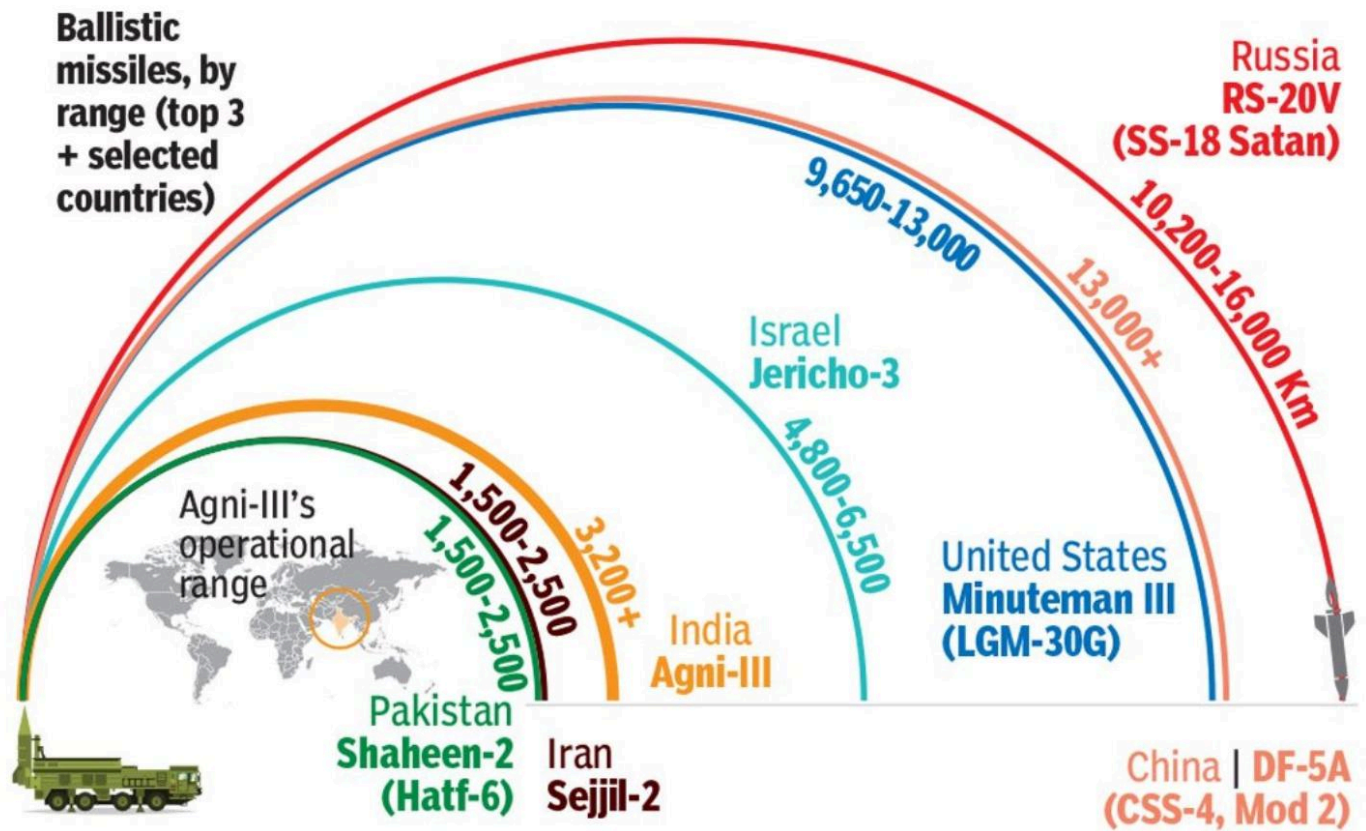
empty threats all day. In fact, you don't even need nuclear weapons: with global delivery capability and enough intercontinental weapons with high-explosive conventional warheads, you can still threaten others. Of course, ICBMs plus nuclear warheads are the best deterrent combination, and will remain so for a long time.



Source: <https://www.voroniapp.com/military/The-Countries-Holding-The-Worlds-Nuclear-Arsenal-5088>

Ballistic Powerhouses: How Far Can the World's Missiles Go?

As many as 31 countries possess ballistic missiles. But very few have intercontinental ballistic missiles (ICBM), which have a range of over 5,500km. India is developing the Agni VI with ICBM range



Source: Arm Control Association

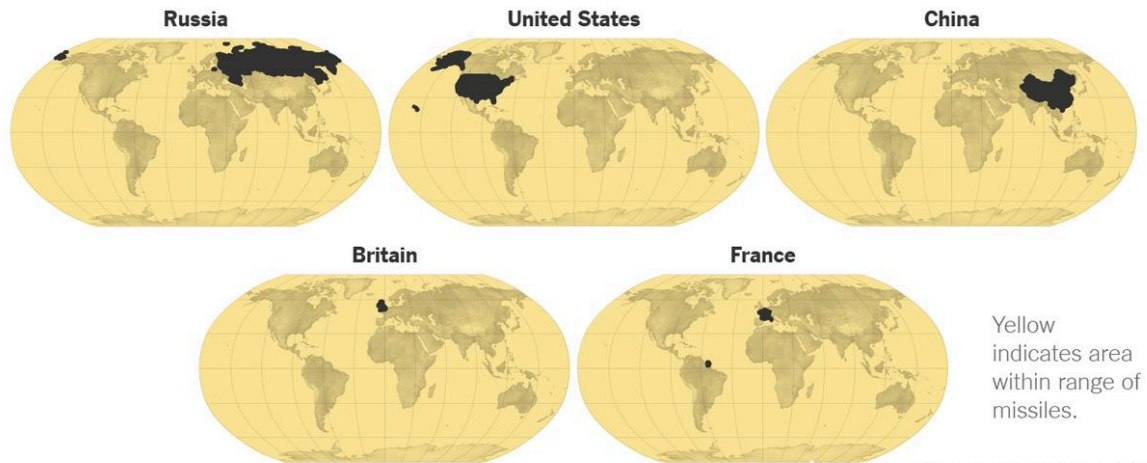
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The figure omits France's submarine-launched ICBMs, the M51.2 and M51.3 (range 8,000–10,000 km), which can cover the globe

Only 5 Nations Can Hit Any Place on Earth With a Missile. For Now.

[Leer en español](#)

By SERGIO PEÇANHA and KEITH COLLINS FEB. 7, 2018



Note: Maps include ranges of land- and submarine-launched missiles. Source: CSIS/US State Defense Project

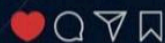
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Source: <https://www.nytimes.com/interactive/2018/02/07/world/asia/north-korea-missile-proliferation-range-intercontinental-iran-pakistan-india.html>

On military satellite technology, according to the figure below (not the latest), the EU has only 44 military satellites, about 8 percent of the total of 544; Russia about 19 percent. As more countries launch military satellites, each country's share will inevitably trend lower; still, more than 5 percent should be the floor — below that, one's presence is too weak. As for anti-satellite weapons, only China, the US, Russia, and India have this capability; Europe does not (France has reportedly promised not to conduct kinetic or explosive destruction tests, to avoid triggering a nuclear arms race, but is testing laser anti-satellite weapons). Still, possessing nuclear weapons with global delivery capability is enough to deter attempts to destroy your satellites, except in a doomsday scenario of total war; the practical impact is limited.



COUNTRIES WITH THE MOST MILITARY SATELLITES



Source: World Population Review

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Beyond this, territory and population also matter. Too small an area or too small a population makes it hard to hold out in protracted military confrontation. So at least about 100 million people (Russia is the least populous pole, at 140 million), and an area of about 3 million square kilometers (Europe

is the smallest pole by area; taking the EU's 3.337 million square kilometers at its founding in 1993 as the reference).

Combining the two, the military standards for a pole are: 1) arms exports at least 5 percent of the world total; 2) nuclear warheads that can cover the globe; 3) military satellites above 5 percent of the world total; 4) population of 100 million; 5) area of 3 million square kilometers.

As weapons technology develops and the accuracy of conventional warheads improves, criterion 2 can be relaxed somewhat: so long as your missiles can cover the globe, the threshold is met.

(3) Politics

Compared with economy and military, politics is in fact the most crucial and most difficult link — and the hardest to predict.

Russia's military is strong and its economy weak, but its state capacity is strong. Russia is called a federation, but it is in fact a centralized state, and the state controls a large share of the oil-and-gas industry, giving it strong fiscal capacity. The EU is the counterexample: Europe is still a confederation of states or a union of states, not yet at the level of a federation. India is a federation. China goes without saying: centralized power, plus state control of finance, infrastructure, steel, and other key basic industries — its state capacity is very strong.

In 2024, China's central government revenue was 10,046.2 billion yuan; total national government revenue was 21,970.2 billion yuan — a share of 45.7 percent.

In 2024, the EU's central revenue was 187 billion euros; the total revenue of all EU member governments was \$7.28 trillion — a share of 2.57 percent.

In 2024, US federal revenue was \$4.92 trillion; total national revenue, \$8.4 trillion — a share of about 58 percent.

This shows that the central government of a "pole" should take in more than 40 percent of national revenue. The EU's case relies entirely on its appeal to member states and on the ideological appeal of the European idea to citizens; its level of institutionalization is too low for global competition. Defense it might manage; offense is hard. Even as a pole, it would be a very weak pole — which in fact is the EU's true position in the world today.

To be a pole, politically one cannot be a loose organization of the tariff-union type like ASEAN or the East African Community; the minimum is the EU level (alliance-level taxation, finance, and central bank). Below that level, one cannot act as an independent entity in global political, economic, and military competition.

III. How Many Poles Does the Multipolar World Have?

(1) The Present

Some Chinese scholars hold that the current world multipolarity is a situation of "two poles, four parties, many powers." If global influence is required to be a pole, this view in effect holds that only the four forces of China, the US, Russia, and Europe count as "poles." Other regional forces, such as India, can only be counted as a transitional form between a "pole" and a sovereign nation-state.

Although international politics trends multipolar, in terms of national strength, influence, and voice, the world is dominated mainly by the two superpowers China and the US — the "two poles." These two poles are not purely geopolitical opposites, nor do they inevitably move toward conflict; they embody competition across the full spectrum of economy, science and technology, military, and culture. Under the China–US bipolar structure, Russia and the EU are two major participants, each seeking strategic autonomy and global influence. The EU, the world's second-largest economy, has a highly integrated market, but its strategic influence is limited by stagnant economic growth, internal political contradictions, and external challenges. Russia, though its economy suffers from Western sanctions, remains a key player in the global order by virtue of its energy resources, nuclear arsenal, and geostrategic position. Within the framework of "two poles, four parties," the regional forces of the Middle East, South America, India, Japan–Korea, and Southeast Asia are all objects of cooperation the "four parties" compete for; these objects share the feature that their economic and technological strength, or their growth potential, is not to be underestimated, and they can in turn intensify the competition of the two poles and the game of the four parties. These "many powers" are not superpowers or entities in the traditional sense, but by virtue of resource and population advantages or special strategic positions, they play an increasingly important role in global governance. Source: The world presents a situation of "two poles, four parties, many powers"

According to the Russian philosopher Dugin, the world today has seven poles: the West (Europe, America, Japan), China, Russia, and India are the formal "poles"; the others — the Islamic Middle East, Africa, and Latin America — are still in the process of rising to polehood. The Russian scholar's criteria carry a strong national particularity, devaluing Europe and elevating India — exactly the opposite of China's view. In the Chinese view, Europe, like Russia, is a weak "pole," while India is not a "pole" at all. And in the view of both Russian and Chinese scholars, the Islamic Middle East, South America, and Africa have not yet developed global influence and cannot be called "poles."

In fact, the new composition of BRICS members includes every civilization and space on Earth that could serve as a separate pole, except for the West, which is still desperately defending its hegemony and unipolar model. But now it faces not a single country, disunited, divided, full of internal and external contradictions, but a united force determined to build a multipolar world, comprising the majority of humanity. This multipolar world will consist of the following civilizations: the West (the US

+ the EU and its dependents, including the once proud and distinctive Japan); China and related countries; Russia (as the integrator of the entire Eurasian space); India and its sphere of influence; the Islamic world (including Shiite Iran and Sunni Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Egypt). From the above we see that we have a world structure with seven poles, composed of seven complete civilizations, of which some independent poles have already formed (the West, China, Russia, India), while others (the Islamic world, Africa, Latin America) are approaching formation. In the context of a seven-pole world (an emerging seven-fold mechanism), when one civilization — Western civilization — claims hegemony, the other six civilizations can deny it that right, accepting only a multipolar order, and considering Western civilization merely one civilization among equals. Source: Alexander Dugin: BRICS expansion marks the birth of a seven-pole world

European scholars variously accept 3 poles (China, US, Europe), 4 (China, US, Russia, Europe), or 5 (China, US, Russia, Europe, India); views are mixed. And the 2025 Munich Security Report even proposed "eight poles."

The 2025 Munich Security Report is titled "Multipolarization." After the introduction, it devotes separate chapters to eight countries and country-unions and why, in the report team's view, each qualifies as a pole of the world: the United States, China, the EU, Russia, India, Japan, Brazil, and South Africa. Source: The Munich report's "eight poles of the world": can jokes hide Europe's confusion?

By the standards analyzed in the previous chapter:

Economy: GDP share of the world 10 percent, minimum 5 percent (if militarily or politically strong). Military: 1) arms exports at least 5 percent of world total; 2) nuclear warheads that can cover the globe; 3) military satellites above 5 percent of world total; 4) population 100 million; 5) area 3 million square kilometers. Politics: centralization at least as strong as the EU's.

Economically, the US, China, and the EU qualify. All other candidates fall below the 5 percent standard: Japan has already dropped below the line, and India has not yet reached it.

Militarily, only China, the US, Europe, and Russia qualify. Japan, Brazil, South Africa, and the Middle Eastern states have no global delivery capability, no nuclear weapons, and very few military satellites. India has nuclear weapons but no global delivery capability.

Many qualify politically, but the Islamic Middle Eastern states, South America, and ASEAN must be excluded — these regions have not yet established even the weakest form of central government, nor a unified central bank.

Taking the intersection, at the present moment only China, the US, and Europe constitute "poles" of the multipolar century — so the present world is tripolar. Russia looks like a pole, but it is really using world-class military force to prop up the territorial claims of a nation-state within its own region.

Russia cannot even integrate its region; it can only grab territory by brute force. It has long lost influence over global issues, looking more like a role that "robs and plunders" in a multipolar world, and its decline is startling. Out of respect for its overwhelming nuclear force and its permanent seat on the UN Security Council, the US and China are willing to call it a pole.

(2) The Medium Term (2050)

If the present world is tripolar, how many poles will there be around 2050? More poles or fewer — or even one?

Below we analyze each candidate in turn.

Based on the following projections:

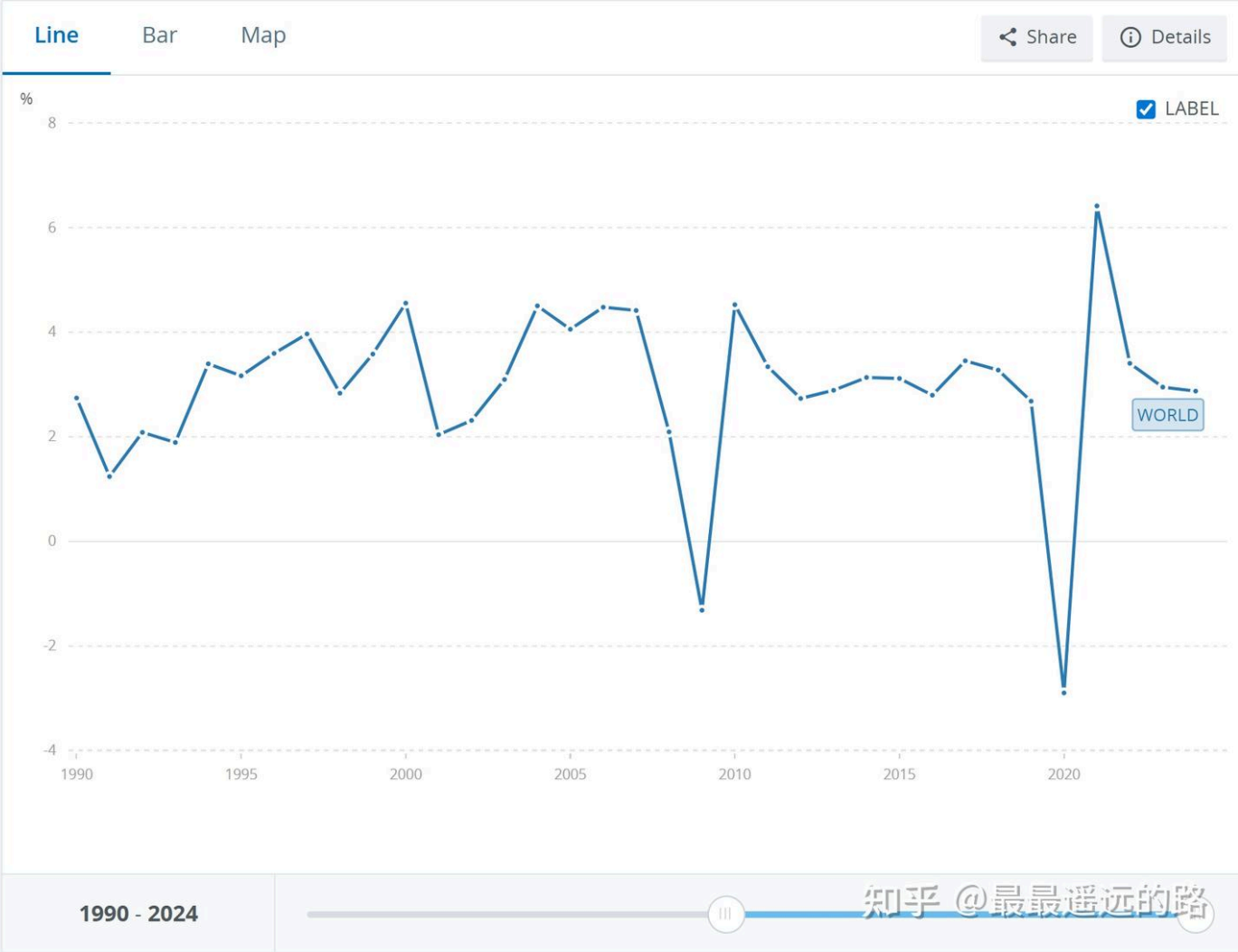
1) GDP

Referring to GDP growth rates over the past 30 years and institutions' projections for the coming decades, and estimating growth of 2.5 percent per year from 2024 to 2050, the world's total GDP in 2050 will be \$211 trillion. This is close to Goldman Sachs's estimate of \$227.9 trillion; all future estimates are uncertain, so let us take the middle value of \$220 trillion. Since the future global monetary situation is hard to predict, we will tentatively keep the dollar as the unit of account.

GDP growth (annual %)

Country official statistics, National Statistical Organizations and/or Central Banks; National Accounts data files, Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD); Staff estimates, World Bank (WB)

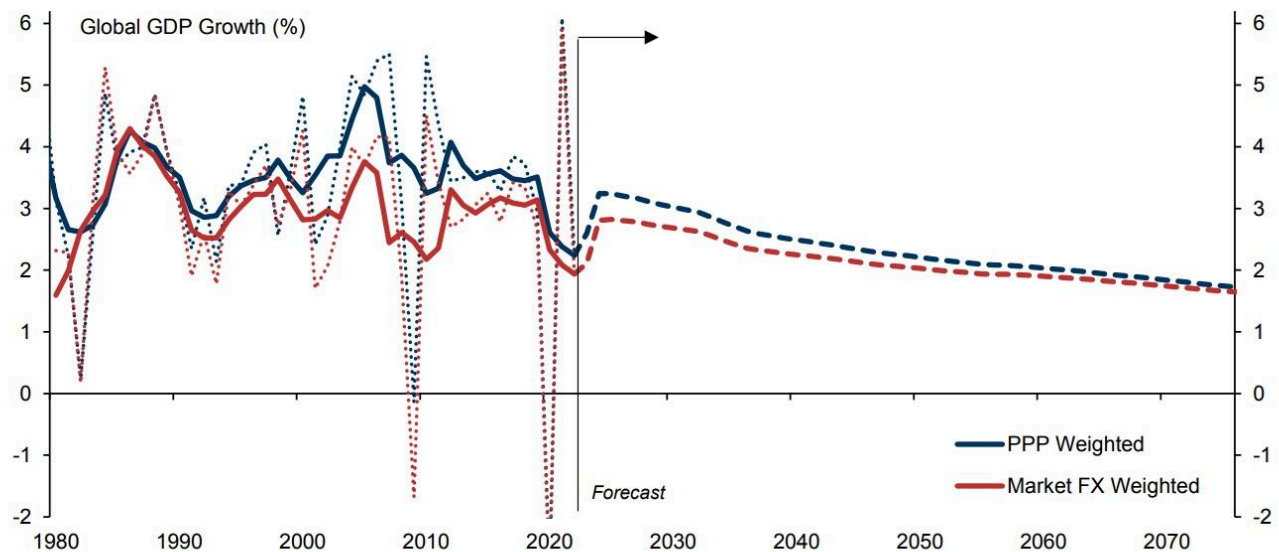
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Source: <https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/NY.GDP.MKTP.KD.ZG?end=2024&start=1990>

Exhibit 1: Global Potential Growth on a Gradually Declining Path

Global GDP growth; solid line - 5Y centred average; dotted line - annual growth



Source: Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research, IMF

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Source: <https://www.goldmansachs.com/pdfs/insights/pages/gs-research/the-path-to-2075-slower-global-growth-but-convergence-remains-intact/report.pdf>

1. China

Even without detailed analysis, it is certain that China — economically (GDP certainly above \$22 trillion), militarily (so long as current military technology does not regress), and politically — is definitely a pole, and the most influential pole, taking the place of the United States in the multipolar world.

For example, according to the official media, China's GDP will reach \$62.63 trillion by 2050, 28.4 percent of the world total — most likely still the world's largest economy.

In terms of economic scale, by 2025, the end of the 14th Five-Year Plan, GDP will reach 146.74 trillion yuan (at 2020 prices), about \$21.26 trillion. By 2035 it will reach 250.45 trillion yuan, about \$36.29 trillion; by 2050, 432.39 trillion yuan, about \$62.65 trillion. Without considering exchange rate movements, China's GDP will reach \$21.26 trillion in 2025, exceeding the US GDP of \$20.61 trillion in 2018. Given US economic growth, around 2030 China's GDP may surpass the US to become the world's largest economy. Source: The Communist Party of China and Chinese-style modernization | The economic prospects of Chinese-style modernization

Militarily, its nuclear arsenal and satellites will certainly grow on a large scale, and its arms-sales share will keep rising from 5 percent. China certainly satisfies the "pole" standard militarily as well.

2. The United States

The US economy is currently about \$30 trillion (2025 estimate). Even if its GDP stays flat, by 2050 the US will still exceed 10 percent of world GDP and meet the economic condition for a pole.

But will America's per-capita GDP, once it loses hegemony — especially dollar hegemony — plunge below Vietnam's? (Some on Zhihu predict Vietnam's per-capita GDP will be three times America's by 2050!)

Such predictions cannot be refuted, but neither can they be believed. For a sudden GDP collapse in peacetime, history gives us one example: Russia in the 1990s. But Russia's case differs from America's. Russia's industrial system was separate from that of the capitalist world; Russian enterprises struggled to survive the transition — that was not a matter of hegemony or not, but of the basic functioning of the economy. Even if America loses dollar hegemony, its manufacturing system remains inside the global market; high-tech industries such as chips, aviation, aerospace, instrumentation, and biopharmaceuticals will still be competitive into the 2040s — completely different from Russia, which was reduced to selling off its heavy industrial equipment as scrap.

Still, let us take the Russian extreme and estimate how bad America's worst case could be.

According to the analysis of Chinese scholars, in the 1990s Russia's GDP, owing to the failure of transition, shrank to 73.6 percent of its pre-transition level (4,513/6,131); after the 2000s, Russia's GDP began to recover.

By the World Bank's method, comparing per-capita GDP growth rates measured in purchasing power parity dollars largely eliminates the effects of price and exchange rate differences between countries, and is thus a more reasonable and feasible comparison of growth rates. Viewed longitudinally, since the transition, in domestic currency Russia's GDP has kept growing — from 19.2 trillion rubles in 1992 to 433.3 trillion in 1998 — and per-capita GDP from \$577 in 1992 to \$3,127 in 1998. But measured in PPP dollars, per-capita GDP fell from \$6,131 in 1992 to \$4,513 in 1998. Source: Ten years of economic transition: an analysis of Russia's mode of economic growth — Institute of Russian, Eastern European and Central Asian Studies, Chinese Academy of Social Sciences

By this ratio, suppose US GDP stops growing from 2025, and after losing hegemony suffers a 1990s-Russia-style collapse: $\$30 \text{ trillion} \times 73.6\% = \22.08 trillion — still above 10 percent of the estimated world GDP of 2050.

In other words, even taking the worst peacetime great-power GDP decline history has seen, America's worst-case 2050 GDP still reaches 10 percent of world GDP, satisfying the economic condition for a pole of the multipolar world.

Militarily, America's current nuclear arsenal and submarines will still provide global deterrence in 2050. On military satellites and anti-satellite capability, given that SpaceX's launch capability still

leads China's by more than a decade, American space military technology is likely to remain world-class in 2050.

On arms sales: Russia, living off its Soviet inheritance, still managed to be the world's second-largest arms exporter after the collapse. Even a declining America should have no trouble keeping a global share above 5 percent.

Politically, the probability of American states seceding is essentially zero.

So by 2050, the US will still be a pole of the multipolar world, and an important one — roughly the equivalent of today's Russia plus the EU combined.

3. The EU

As America faces reality and accepts multipolarity, American power will gradually withdraw from Europe, and Europe's drive for autonomy will strengthen. As China rises, America will come to support Europe's "strategic autonomy" from China, just as China today supports Europe's strategic autonomy from America.

This is not the author's imagination. In fact, Sino-European industrial integration is far deeper than Sino-American. By the time the balance between China and the US has completely reversed, Chinese and European industry may well have finished merging. Since the EU has gone earlier and farther down the road of industrial integration with China, America will then have to politically push European autonomy, or else Europe will be in danger of following China in international affairs.

Below are some news reports on Sino-European industrial integration; readers can search for similar reports themselves. These reports show that industrial integration with China is a trend in European politics, very different from the prevailing views in the American ruling class.

The Paper: In recent years, the EU has emphasized "de-risking" and "competitive cooperation" in its China policy. Against the background of Trump's tariffs, should the EU adjust this approach? Prodi: First, I do not think the current policy works, because global value chains are already tightly linked... Helping Europe achieve "strategic autonomy" serves China's interests. China has changed; it is no longer merely a producer of low costs or low prices, but a high-tech country, and its relationship with the European economy is utterly different from the past. Flexibility in foreign policy means we must readjust existing trade and investment relations. In my view, Europe achieving "strategic autonomy" serves the common interests of China and Europe, but it must be driven by a firmer European policy and a more flexible Chinese policy. Source: Former European Commission President Prodi: Europe's "strategic autonomy" serves China–EU common interests

On December 3, 2025, French President Macron led a delegation to China in person; the core purpose was technology sharing and investment cooperation, aiming to push Europe to use Chinese breakthroughs in batteries and photovoltaics for its green transition. French media coverage

emphasized the importance of bilateral relations while not concealing its core concern — "seeking technology." This scene clearly shows that the decades-old global industrial division of labor of "Western innovation, Eastern manufacturing" is being fundamentally overturned. In citing representative examples of China's advanced technology, Macron specifically mentioned the Chinese PV company DAS Solar, which is investing in France. The project's special significance lies in marking the formation of a new type of China–Europe cooperation: what China exports is no longer a single product but green core technology and service solutions; Europe relies not only on capital but on its deep industrial base and the imperative of transition. The interaction of the two sides on the new-energy chessboard is redefining the new global rules of "technology flows" and "industrial symbiosis." During his visit, Macron explicitly said France can provide competitive carbon-free electricity, a mature ecosystem of innovation, a high-quality labor force, and transparent, stable, predictable government support, offering a good development space for project investment — precisely matching the core needs of China's leading enterprises in global deployment: no longer one-way product exports, but a deep fusion of local production capacity, cutting-edge technology, and high-quality resources. Source: Europe "seeking" Chinese PV technology? Macron names this PV company

On April 11, Sánchez also met Chinese business leaders in Beijing. According to media footage, representatives of Envision Energy, Chery, Leapmotor, CATL, CTG International, China Energy Engineering, Hithium, Tianqi Lithium, GCL, and Cailu Group attended the symposium. Before the symposium, the prime minister met separately with Envision chairman Zhang Lei, Chery chairman Yin Tongyue, and Leapmotor chairman and CEO Zhu Jiangming. From the firms and the list, it is clear that Spain strongly desires to attract China's new-energy industry chain and is seeking large investment in batteries, green hydrogen, and automobile manufacturing. Source: <https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/lSoggpDFoPhsT1AzI9q89Q>

Because of EU–China industrial integration, under the background of global industrialization, Europe's economy may well still see some growth — its future may be even brighter than America's.

The EU's GDP in 2024 was about \$19 trillion; at the conservative rate of 1 percent annual growth, by 2050 it will still be \$24.6 trillion, above 10 percent of the estimated world GDP of 2050 — satisfying the economic condition for a pole of the multipolar world.

Militarily, the EU currently depends on the US for both nuclear and conventional weapons. As America declines and cannot attend to itself, Europe must restore its own military strength to become a pole.

The Chinese official media reports on Europe as follows. Under the great transformation of the multipolar world, Europe is also moving. The EU has already launched a plan to strengthen the defense industry, investing 800 billion, with procurement focused on European firms. Under the real

pressure of Russian military power, plus European industry's competition with China, Europe is being pushed toward a "war economy"; the European military-industrial machine has started. Whether European defense industry can develop fully independently of America remains to be seen, but with real money being poured in, its relative strength is certain to grow. Britain also realizes that after American power withdraws, Europe must rely on itself, and has joined the European movement for defense autonomy. Relying on its own strong industrial base, by 2030 Europe's output of conventional weapons (tanks, shells, missiles, drones, fighters) will likely surpass Russia's. Europe has many loyal customers for conventional weapons; maintaining a world arms-export share above 5 percent before 2050 should not be a problem.

Facing US policy uncertainty, the EU intends to strengthen internal cooperation in defense and reduce dependence on America. In March, the EU adopted its first "White Paper on the Future of European Defense," proposing a "true European defense equipment market" and joint procurement in seven key areas — air and missile defense, unmanned and counter-unmanned systems, ammunition, etc. — to achieve self-production and self-procurement. The subsequent "ReArm Europe Plan / Readiness 2030" planned over €800 billion (about \$942 billion) in investment to help members increase defense spending. In October, the EU issued the "Defense Readiness Roadmap 2030," further clarifying the direction of arms building over the next five years, aiming to narrow capability gaps among members and put the EU in full readiness by 2030. Source: China Defense Daily: 2025 — the global security order undergoes deep adjustment

According to a detailed list from the German parliament's budget committee, from September 2025 to December 2026 Germany plans 154 major arms procurement projects totaling nearly €83 billion. The plan clearly favors European domestic defense firms; American firms get only about 8 percent of procurement. At present the only US weapons likely to win contracts are torpedoes for the P-8A patrol aircraft and the Patriot air-defense missile system with its launchers. European countries are showing a tendency to reject American weapons, and this tendency has long been visible. In March, the EU launched the "ReArm Europe" process, pushing member states to jointly invest, procure, and expand capacity in defense. Many countries then followed, abandoning the F-35. Portugal was first to renounce the F-35 as its next-generation fighter, turning instead to Sweden's Gripen or France's Rafale. Spain decided to buy more European Typhoons and to speed up joint development of a sixth-generation fighter with France and Germany. Poland, though it has received its first 2 F-35s, has shelved the purchase of the remaining 32, prioritizing upgrades to its F-16s. Source: China Defense Daily: European equipment procurement leans toward "Made in Europe"

Under the plan, Britain will also greatly expand its submarine production bases at Barrow and Derby, building a new nuclear submarine every 18 months. The related defense investment will directly create 30,000 high-skill jobs nationwide, and over the next decade 30,000 apprenticeship places and 14,000 graduate posts. Besides nuclear submarines, the government announced procurement of up

to 7,000 domestically made long-range weapons, further building up arsenal stocks and supporting about 800 jobs. It also created a new "CyberEM" cyber command and added £1 billion for digital military capabilities. Source: China Economic Weekly: Britain "prepares for war"!

In mid-August, the Financial Times reported that analysis of radar satellite data on 150 production facilities of 37 European defense companies showed that construction activity at European arms plants has accelerated since the Russia–Ukraine war. Defense firms are expanding at three times the peacetime rate, adding over 7 million square meters of new industrial land. EU Defense and Space Commissioner Andrius Kubilius said Europe's annual production capacity of large-caliber artillery ammunition is expected to rise from about 300,000 rounds in 2022 to about 2 million by the end of this year. Germany's Rheinmetall says its annual capacity for 155mm shells will rise from about 70,000 in 2022 to about 1.1 million by 2027. MBDA's plant in Schrobenhausen, Bavaria, is expanding production of the Enforcer portable missile and has taken a NATO order worth \$5.6 billion to produce 1,000 Patriot GEM-T surface-to-air missiles in Europe. Source: China Defense Daily: opportunities and challenges coexist in the European defense industry

On nuclear weapons, France's nuclear force satisfies requirements in both range and survivability; Britain depends on the US, but on the whole can defend itself. The main problem is political: can France provide a nuclear umbrella for other EU members? If another EU country suffered a nuclear strike, would France be willing to retaliate with nuclear weapons? For European nuclear forces to develop, the fundamental need is to resolve the EU's political-institutional problem; the current mode of agreement among member states does not solve the root problem.

Europe has now basically completed the "civil society" process of economic integration: unified currency, unified labor market (free movement of labor), unified tariffs, free movement of capital and money. A unified government has taken embryonic shape — there is a court, a central bank, a parliament, and the EU can issue debt. The next step, to go further, requires the EU to transcend nation-states and achieve a "European federation." This transformation looks very difficult. Whether it can be brought about under the competitive pressures of the multipolar world (e.g., to prevent forces like Russia from profiting from the confusion), and the political-system transition accomplished, is the decisive factor in the EU's position in the future multipolar world.

If the EU upgrades to a "European federation," then France's nuclear weapons become the EU's nuclear weapons, and with greater capital investment their quantity and quality will both rise. A unified European army, the "European army," will be built independent of the national armies. The EU may well become a very important pole of the future multipolar world.

If the EU remains as it is, or is even broken apart by various "eurosceptic" parties, it will find it hard to be a pole of the future multipolar world. In particular, with China's high-end industries developed, the EU's special position in industry will be greatly weakened; winning global influence on the

strength of 10 percent of world GDP alone, without corresponding political and military cohesion, is hard to sustain — big but not strong.

4. India

First, the economy. India's current GDP is about \$4 trillion. Since India is still in the phase of rapid industrialization, with urbanization below 50 percent and a large surplus rural labor force moving to the cities to support its capital accumulation, India will most likely maintain high growth: at a relatively low average of 6.5 percent, India's GDP in 2050 will reach \$19.3 trillion; at 7 percent, \$21.7 trillion; at 8 percent, \$27.4 trillion.

On the low estimate, India's GDP reaches 8.8 percent of the world; if growth is a bit higher, it can exceed 10 percent, roughly meeting the economic-scale requirement to be regarded as a global "pole."

Militarily, India mainly needs to build global nuclear deterrence. India's Agni-VI in development is claimed to reach 10,000 km, though some say only 6,000. By 2050, India should have little trouble producing a rail- or road-mobile missile with a 10,000-km range.

According to NDTV, the missile will undergo final tests before induction into India's Strategic Forces Command. The Agni-V has a range of over 5,000 km. One source said: "This is India's strategic asset of deterrence," noting that the Agni-V is the most modern of the Agni series with advanced navigation equipment. NDTV reported the first launch of Agni-V on April 19, 2012. Six tests have been conducted so far, the last successful launch in early June this year. The missile has never failed a launch. The Indian military currently fields four Agni variants: Agni-I with a range of 700 km, Agni-II 2,000 km, Agni-III and Agni-IV 2,500–3,500 km. The Agni-VI is under development, with a range up to 10,000 km and submarine-launch capability. Source: India develops the Agni-6 ICBM, with a range of over 10,000 km and submarine launch

India's military satellite plans are also ambitious.

Recently, Indian Chief of Defence Staff General Anil Chauhan announced at a defense space symposium that India will launch 52 dedicated intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance satellites, expanding space-based assets to strengthen military capability. The 52 satellites will be developed and launched by ISRO with private firms, deployed in LEO, MEO, and GEO orbits for comprehensive coverage and operational resilience, greatly enhancing surveillance, reconnaissance, movement tracking, and cross-border real-time intelligence collection. The satellites will carry advanced sensors and high-resolution imaging systems, possibly with synthetic aperture radar, enabling all-weather operation. General Chauhan also announced that India's military space doctrine may be finalized within three months. The doctrine will be the programmatic document guiding the armed forces' space capability building, emphasizing space's role in military operations, incorporating space assets into joint operations, and systematically planning counter-space capability development to ensure the

security of key space assets. Its issuance marks India formally bringing space into a new operational domain. Source: India plans a large all-orbit ISR satellite constellation

In conventional weapons, India has also made progress; see the author's other article: "How strong is India's defense industry? Not as weak as you think."

At present India's arms sales are small, mainly some missiles; other main equipment like aircraft and tanks basically cannot be sold. But India's drones are developing fast and, relying on price advantage, may shine in the African market. In 2024–25, India's arms exports were \$2.76 billion; China's \$3.2 billion; the world total \$67.9 billion — India has already reached 4 percent. The Indian government is now actively promoting arms exports and seems confident. By 2050, India's share of world arms exports may reach more than 10 percent. Readers may ask: if India's weapons are so poor, why does anyone buy them? Note that India mainly sells missiles, artillery, and the like — none of the aircraft and tanks people mock — showing that India does have good things the international market accepts.

Indian military sources say the Defense Export Council, established on the initiative of Prime Minister Modi, aims mainly to integrate defense industrial resources and unleash the economic potential of "Made in India" in this field. Statistics show India currently has 9 state defense enterprises, 41 ordnance factories under the Ministry of Defense, various R&D laboratories, and nearly 6,000 small and medium private enterprises related to the defense industry. As the industry grows rapidly, India is seeking arms export opportunities. Under India's export targets, arms exports will reach \$5.77 billion in 2029, more than double 2024. India is reportedly taking measures to boost defense exports, including simplifying the defense industry licensing system, relaxing export controls, offering credit lines to foreign countries to import Indian arms, and authorizing defense attachés to promote exports. India's BrahMos missile, Pinaka multiple rocket launchers, TC-20 truck-mounted guns, and wheeled infantry fighting vehicles have already been exported to many countries. Indian media say the council will expand arms exports through marketing strategy design and simplified export procedures. Source: India plans to establish a defense export agency — Xinhua

So, considering the scale of arms sales, nuclear weapon development, military space technology, population (1.6 billion), and territory (nearly 3 million square kilometers), India basically qualifies militarily as a pole by 2050.

5. Others

Russia is not even a true pole now; by 2050 it will be even less of one. Its remaining military power — apart from nuclear weapons, which can hardly be used in actual combat — has uncertain deterrent value. By 2050, Russia's military position will likely resemble Japan's position in industry. Still, with its nuclear weapons, it can defend its territory: some in China covet Russia's Far East, but as long as Russia test-fires a nuke from time to time, such thoughts must remain in the heads of social media authors.

Japan, Brazil, South Africa, Turkey, and similar forces — owing to population size, territory, lack of nuclear weapons, and low completeness of conventional forces — will still not be able to be "poles" by 2050; they remain regional forces, and only by integrating regional power can they become true "poles."

Japan's opportunity lies in integrating ASEAN. ASEAN is hard to integrate, and militarily weak; without incorporating Japan and Korea, it can hardly become a pole. But if Japan and Korea try to integrate ASEAN, they will meet fierce resistance from the great power China. ASEAN is not like the EU: the EU is far away, and China's stakes in European integration are less direct. But ASEAN is next door; if a union of nearly a billion people formed, and joined India in checking China, it would be a geopolitical nightmare for China. ASEAN integration therefore has quite uncertain prospects.

Turkey's opportunity lies in uniting Iran, Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Egypt, and bringing in Pakistan as well, to form a Middle Eastern Islamic regional alliance reaching a degree of integration like the EU's. Of course, Turkey might directly join the EU — that is another matter. The Islamic Middle Eastern alliance is discussed separately in the next section.

If Brazil can integrate South America, build an independent military industry, complete the main combat equipment of the three services, and develop long-range missiles, it could — even without nuclear weapons — reach a quasi-global "pole" level. But South America is far behind; we will not expand the analysis for now.

South Africa or the AU has little chance before Africa's heavy industry develops. Rapid industrialization in sub-Saharan Africa will unfold on a large scale after the 2050s; heavy industry will then grow fast. But the upgrade from heavy industry to military industry takes a long time and is hard to predict; we will not discuss it here.

So by 2050, China, the US, and India are three fairly strong poles. Europe is also a pole, though its strength is uncertain. Finally, the Middle East may form a pole, but with far more uncertainty than the EU; it is treated separately in the next chapter. Other regions have so far shown neither the conditions nor the trend to form a pole.

(3) A Union of States That May Upgrade to a "Pole"

By 2050, if the Islamic states of the Middle East can complete their integration, they may transform from the imperialist racetrack into a "pole" with global influence.

First, the economy.

Several major Middle East and North African countries have entered the acceleration phase of industrialization.

As the figure below shows, by several key industrial indicators, the core Middle Eastern countries have entered the middle or late stage of industrialization.

国家	GDP	人口（万）	钢产量（万吨）	人均钢产量（吨）	人均发电量（度）	炼油能力（万吨）	人均炼油量（吨）	人口（2050估计）
土耳其	1.32万亿	8500	3690	0.434（接近中国2010年水平）	3710（超过中国2010年水平）	2800	0.329（中国2010年代水平）	9130万
伊朗	4170亿	9200	3140	0.341（中国2000年代水平）	3802（超过中国2010年水平）	14700	1.597826087（超过中国水平）	1亿
沙特	1.24万亿	3500	960	0.274（中国2000年代水平）	12710（超过中国当前水平）	16277	4.650571429（超过中国水平）	4000万
阿联酋	5520亿	1100	370	0.336（中国2000年代水平）	15500（超过中国当前水平）	5544	5.04（超过中国水平）	1500万
伊拉克	2790亿	4600	300	0.065（中国1990年代水平）	3400（超过中国2010年水平）	6412	1.393913043（超过中国水平）	7200万
埃及	3830亿	10600	1070	0.101（刚达到中国2000年水平）	1910（达到中国2005年水平）	3400	0.320754717（中国2010年代水平）	1.6亿

Source: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/List_of_countries_by_electricity_consumption,
https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/List_of_countries_by_steel_production, etc.

Moreover, Indian and Chinese enterprises are exporting heavy industrial capacity to the Middle East, and have begun to transfer manufacturing capacity in automobiles, textiles, and other sectors. Over the next 5–10 years, Middle Eastern industry will develop even more.

The core countries' population will approach 500 million by 2050; if per-capita GDP reaches \$15,000, their total GDP will reach \$7.5 trillion. Pakistan's 380 million people (low estimate for 2050) with per-capita GDP of \$4,000 by 2050 (with joint assistance from China and the Gulf states like Saudi Arabia) gives a GDP of about \$1.5 trillion. The Middle Eastern countries plus Pakistan, Qatar, Oman, Kuwait, Jordan, and others reach about \$10 trillion — close to 5 percent of world GDP in 2050. Though far below the 10 percent line, the Middle East controls the world's oil-and-gas belt and key trade routes, and its economic position can support a somewhat weaker "pole."

Next, the military.

Militarily, a Middle Eastern alliance including Pakistan, Turkey, and Iran actually has considerable potential, because these countries have essentially acquired the military capabilities a global "pole" requires.

First, Pakistan has nuclear weapons and can provide the highest level of deterrence. In a context where great powers control the spread of nuclear technology, possessing an internationally recognized semi-legitimate nuclear status is very precious. If Pakistan can produce missiles with a range of 5,000–8,000 km, it can deter most of the globe. For the Middle East to become a pole, it really must have Pakistan.

The Hatf series of short-range ballistic missiles were Pakistan's starting point in ballistic missile development, with ranges of 70–300 km in several sub-variants, forming the backbone of Pakistan's strikes on India's shallow-to-deep rear. The Ghauri series was Pakistan's major attempt to break the 1,000-km range, with effective ranges of 1,350–1,500 km and terminal dive speeds of Mach 3.5. The Shaheen series of medium- and long-range ballistic missiles is touted by Pakistan as "the sharpest knife for solving strategic problems"; the Shaheen-1/2/3 variants achieved the technological leap from single to multi-stage boosters and from single to multiple independently targetable reentry vehicles, covering 750–2,750 km — enough to precisely strike major targets across India — and are an

important part of Pakistan's nuclear deterrence. Notably, unlike India's ever-longer Agni series, Pakistan has not blindly joined a "missile range race" but emphasizes practical combat performance. Against India's missile defense system, Pakistan has in recent years focused on the Ababeel ballistic missile, with an effective range of 2,200 km, MIRV capability, and the ability to carry small nuclear warheads. According to a June 2024 report by a Swedish institution on global nuclear forces, India and Pakistan have 172 and 170 nuclear warheads respectively. Source: China Aerospace News: the India–Pakistan conflict intensifies; both sides' missiles compete impressively

Second, Iran has a strong industrial base.

For example, Iran can build internationally advanced gas turbines and has already exported them to Russia.

On Monday, Iranian Energy Minister Abbas Aliabadi addressed industry leaders and officials, declaring a new era of energy independence. He proudly presented the MGT-75, Iran's first self-designed and built F-class gas turbine, calling it an "engineering masterpiece" and "the glory of Iranian engineers," stressing that this milestone was achieved thanks to young engineers who proved they can develop technology meeting the highest international standards. He said the MGT-75 project marks a major step in the development and modernization of Iran's power plant industry, benefiting all citizens. Fakhir Tabatabai revealed the immense effort behind this engineering miracle — over 500,000 hours of precision engineering work — proving that MAPNA subsidiaries TUGA and Parto have cultivated high-level technical expertise. Deputy Energy Minister Homayoun Haeri praised MAPNA's growth from manufacturer to owner of proprietary technology, confirming that the group is now a recognized, important, and efficient brand in five or six technologically advanced countries, serving both the economic and strategic goals of the country's power sector and cementing its role as a pillar of Iran's energy security and technological strength. The MGT-75 is a milestone breakthrough for Iran's energy sector: as the country's first fully indigenous F-class gas turbine, it delivers 222 MW in simple cycle and 330 MW in combined cycle, with thermal efficiency over 59 percent. The significance of this turbine is considerable. Full-scale production of advanced F-class gas turbines was previously concentrated in only seven technologically advanced countries; Iran has now joined them. The US, Germany, and Japan have long led this field, represented respectively by GE, Siemens Energy, and Mitsubishi Power; Italy's Ansaldo Energia as an established manufacturer also holds an important position; in recent years China (via SOEs like Dongfang Electric) and Russia (via Power Machines, mainly for domestic use) have also achieved indigenous production. Source: Iran's MGT-75: an indigenous F-class breakthrough approaching H-class, joining the world's seven gas-turbine manufacturing powers

Iran can put its own military satellites into orbit with its own rockets. Countries with space-launch capability

in the world are few indeed.

Iranian state media said Iran on Friday (December 6) launched a two-stage "Simorgh" rocket with a total payload of 660 pounds (300 kg). According to Reuters, the payloads included a space tug named Saman-1, capable of lifting satellites to higher orbits; the Fakhr-1 cubesat; and an undisclosed "research payload." Source: Iran launches military satellite, putting its largest payload into orbit

Third, Turkey's conventional weapons R&D is strong.

Turkey's defense achievements have won international recognition: its arms exports already exceed 10 percent of the world total, with considerable room for further growth. Turkey's weapons development covers a wide range — all three services, and various missiles, including hypersonic ones. Turkey does not, however, have its own launch vehicle technology; in this respect the Middle East still has to rely on Iran.

According to data from Turkey's Defense Industry Agency, the country's arms exports in 2024 reached \$7.154 billion, up 29 percent year on year, a record. Turkey ranked 11th in the world arms export ranking. Turkish Aerospace Industries, Aselsan, and two other defense firms made the global top-100 defense firms, regarded as having strong competitive potential in the European arms market over the next 5-10 years. Aselsan's ASELFLIR-500 electro-optical reconnaissance system, for example, has been exported to 16 countries. Turkey's arms products mainly target European and Central Asian countries: Poland and Azerbaijan are major customers for armored vehicles, TB-2 drones, and attack helicopters; Portugal has ordered Ada-class corvettes and several patrol boats; Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Qatar, and other Middle Eastern countries are new buyers. Saudi Arabia reportedly plans to buy 100 of the new-generation "KAAN" fighter. On this basis, Turkey's Defense Ministry has set new annual sales targets: exports above \$8 billion, over \$10 billion within two years, and \$11 billion by 2028. The entire defense industry chain's revenue will grow from \$12.2 billion in 2024 to \$26 billion in 2028, making it a major pillar industry. A Defense Industry Committee spokesman said the Altay T1 main battle tank's entry into army service marks the start of Turkey's transformation and iteration of land combat equipment, and adds a new export product. Foreign media analysis says the Altay series will be the strongest competitor to Germany's Leopard in Europe, with clear technical and price advantages. Testing of Turkey's two next-generation aircraft — the KAAAN fighter and the T-625 helicopter — will be essentially complete within the year: six prototypes of the former will be delivered this year; the latter, dubbed the Turkish "Black Hawk," will be fitted with a domestic engine in the first half of the year. Source: Turkey expands its arms export market

According to foreign media, Turkey recently completed a live-fire test of its indigenous "Tayfun" hypersonic ballistic missile. The missile hit its target precisely, signaling the end of development and the transition to mass production and deployment. Video released by Turkish defense firm Roketsan showed the missile mounted on an 8x8 transporter-erector-launcher vehicle, using twin cold launch — demonstrating high mobility and rapid strike capability. The Tayfun was first publicly unveiled at the 17th International Defense Industry Fair in Istanbul, July 22-27. After the successful test, Turkish

defense circles consider it combat-ready. The missile is a two-stage solid-fuel design, about 7-8 meters long, with a range over 1,000 km and a maximum speed of Mach 6; its terminal maneuvering capability can effectively penetrate existing air defenses. Truck-mounted, it supports rapid repositioning and "shoot-and-scoot" tactics suited to Turkey's complex terrain. Source: Turkey's indigenous hypersonic missile completes test launch

Fourth, the GCC states have abundant capital and can use financial power to push regional integration of the Middle East's Muslim states.

How much petrodollar firepower do the Gulf Arab states actually command? Their sovereign wealth funds currently total \$5.4 trillion, over a third of the world total; four of the world's top ten sovereign wealth funds belong to Gulf Arab states. Counting sovereign wealth funds plus family and private investment funds, Gulf Arab capital may reach \$15 trillion. As of 2022, these countries held \$5.24 trillion in overseas assets — the UAE \$1.79 trillion, Saudi Arabia \$1.35 trillion, Kuwait \$1.09 trillion. After the so-called "Arab Spring" of 2011, because Egypt's stability bears on the security of the whole Arab world, the Gulf Arab states kept supplying Egypt with funds on a rapidly growing scale: from 2013 to 2022, the UAE, Saudi Arabia, and Kuwait injected \$34 billion into Egypt in various forms, and in 2024 the UAE again pledged \$35 billion of investment. Clearly, profit is not the primary consideration in Gulf investment in Egypt. Before Turkey's May 2023 election, the UAE announced a \$50 billion-plus investment deal with Turkey, with an obvious political tint of supporting President Erdogan. Thanks to their financial advantage, the Gulf Arab states also wield great political influence on the postwar reconstruction of Syria, Lebanon, and Gaza. Source: How great is the political influence of Gulf capital

Pakistan's finance ministry confirmed that Saudi Arabia has announced a \$1 billion oil financing facility for Pakistan's FY2025-26 and will roll over \$5 billion of existing deposits. The new facility will help Pakistan meet energy import needs and ease pressure on foreign reserves. Of the \$5 billion in Saudi deposits, \$2 billion matures in December and \$3 billion in June 2026; after rollover they will remain with the State Bank of Pakistan. Source: Saudi Arabia provides \$6 billion in economic support to Pakistan

Saudi Investment Minister Khalid Al-Falih said Thursday that Saudi Arabia plans to allocate a large share of its \$200 billion annual construction and materials procurement contracts to Pakistan. Speaking at the 2024 Pakistan-Saudi business forum, Al-Falih said: "Saudi Arabia is the world's largest construction site; in the coming years we will award construction and materials procurement contracts worth about \$1.8 trillion." He stressed that much of the inputs for these contracts will rely on imports, with a strong preference for sourcing from Pakistan. The Saudi minister's visit came as Pakistan seeks to strengthen trade and investment ties with friendly countries amid a prolonged economic crisis that has drained foreign reserves and devalued the currency. Source: Saudi Arabia pledges \$200 billion a year in construction contracts to Pakistan

In November 2024, a WAM report noted that the UAE is Pakistan's third-largest trading partner, with bilateral trade of 25.7 billion dirhams. The two countries cooperate closely in energy, trade, and even military affairs. In 2019, the UAE deposited \$3 billion in Pakistan's central bank to help "boost liquidity" and address its balance-of-payments crisis; in 2021, the UAE pledged about \$2 billion in aid to help Pakistan through financial difficulties. Source: How close are Pakistan's relations with Middle Eastern countries? Closer than you think

Fifth, in the multipolar context, intra-regional economic and military cooperation is strengthening. Besides headline news like the planned Arab-Islamic army and the Saudi-Pakistani military alliance, the real military and economic cooperation among the Islamic Middle Eastern states is deepening.

According to Turkey's Minute news site, Bloomberg, citing informed Turkish officials, reported that Turkey is in deep talks with Pakistan on establishing assembly facilities for Turkish combat drones, aiming to further expand its fast-growing defense industry's overseas market. Turkey and Pakistan already maintain close defense cooperation: Ankara builds frigates for the Pakistani navy under a co-production agreement and is modernizing several of its F-16s. Turkish officials said Turkey also wants Pakistan to join its "KAAN" fifth-generation fighter project. Source: Turkey and Pakistan may build a drone assembly center: Turkey accelerates expansion of its defense export map

Cairo, August 27, 2025: Turkish defense technology company Havelsan and Egypt's Arab Organization for Industrialization (AOI) signed an agreement in Cairo on co-production of VTOL unmanned aerial vehicles, marking a substantive and important step in Turkish-Egyptian defense cooperation. Relations between Egypt and Turkey deteriorated sharply after the 2013 ouster of Muslim Brotherhood leader Morsi, leading to severed diplomatic ties, recalled ambassadors, and mutual accusations. In July 2023 the two countries restored full ambassadorial relations and exchanged ambassadors, normalizing ties after a decade-long freeze. He noted that "production processes for unmanned ground vehicles between Havelsan and Egypt's Kader factory have also started." Havelsan General Manager Mehmet Akif Nacar said at the signing: "We are very pleased to work with a strong partner like the Arab Organization for Industrialization. This cooperation will bring autonomous UAV technology to the region, enhance local production capacity, and help us make a strong entry into the African market." Source: https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/oyN5gQFE_oViiYaPq_lxdA

If the Gulf states at the core of Saudi Arabia and the UAE can pull together Turkey, Iran, and Pakistan — the big powers of the region — and add Egypt's abundant, high-quality labor force, building a regional organization like the EU with deep economic and military integration, then the Middle East could become a new pole. With American power in decline, a rising China in need of partners, Russia fully withdrawn, and this round of industrialization favoring the region's economic integration, various factors are opening the political space for Middle Eastern unity. Whether to seize

the opportunity is up to the wisdom of the Middle East's ruling classes. If achieved, the region's "century of humiliation" could end, and the great rejuvenation of the Arab-Islamic world be completed.

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